
“Not a single soldier in the whole army ever loved or respected him.”

PRIVATE SAM WATKINS WRITING OF BRAGG IN HIS MEMOIRS,
1882

During 1862–63, Braxton Bragg was the most prominent Confederate general in the Western Theater. In some ways he resembled Stonewall Jackson—both men were harsh disciplinarians, quarrelsome, and uncommunicative, and had a poor relationship with their subordinates. The big difference was that Bragg’s character failings were not offset by outstanding success in the field. From the start of his military career he showed himself irritable and argumentative, and a harsh disciplinarian. He meticulously enforced the minutiae of military procedure, although he frequently bucked the authority of those above him in the chain of command.

Serving as an artillery officer in the War with Mexico in 1846–48, Bragg proved his courage and steadiness, yet so alienated the men serving under him that he reportedly survived two attempts on his life by his own soldiers. An enthusiastic supporter of the Confederate cause, Bragg welcomed the bombardment of Fort Sumter in 1861 by writing that you could “reach the sensibilities of such dogs only through their heads and a big stick.”

Campaign in Mississippi

Consigned to the backwater of the Gulf Coast for the first year of the Civil War, Bragg leaped at the chance to take his army to join the forces in the front line at Corinth, Mississippi, in spring 1862. His performance at Shiloh in April was impressive for the determination with which he pressed home his corps’ attack on the Union defenses. But he lacked subtlety or tactical flair, and soldiers’ lives